

EVERYDAY MILLIONAIRES

Anna was born in Germany, but her parents immigrated to the United States when she was nine years old. The family moved in with Anna's aunt in southern Florida, and her father got a job as a property caretaker as the family got acclimated and learned to speak and read English. The immigrant family never had a lot of money, but Anna is grateful that they never lacked for the things that really mattered.

Anna began working right out of college. She also met and married Neal, who she says grew up in a "well-off" family. Well-off or not, they never received any inheritance from either family and were on their own from day one, each working two jobs in the early years of their marriage to get off to a good start. Neal spent his entire career as a computer programmer working in IT, but Anna tried her hand at several different jobs. She spent the first seventeen years of her career at an insurance company, then switched to part-time retail work when she and Neal had kids. She later did some IT work before moving on to a position in the admissions department of a law school, where she ultimately retired from. Looking back, she said she and Neal were both paid well throughout their working lives, but their salaries were "nothing extraordinary." The key to their wealth wasn't high-paying jobs; it was what they *did* with those incomes.

The couple originally set a goal to retire at age forty-five. To get there, they put as much money into their 401(k) plans and other investments (for the bridge period) as possible throughout their careers. They kept their investing strategy simple and let the 401(k) do its work. Their focus was on continually increasing contributions and always taking every penny of their employer matches. They never missed any money that was automatically deducted out of their paychecks, Anna said, so staying committed to the 401(k) was easy. The couple kept their spending in check, lived in a modest house, and even shared one car for a long time. Whatever they didn't spend, they put into their investments. Eventually, all that hard work paid off. The couple missed their early retirement goal by a few years, but they both retired at age fifty with plenty of money—over \$2 million in net worth—to live on for the rest of their lives.